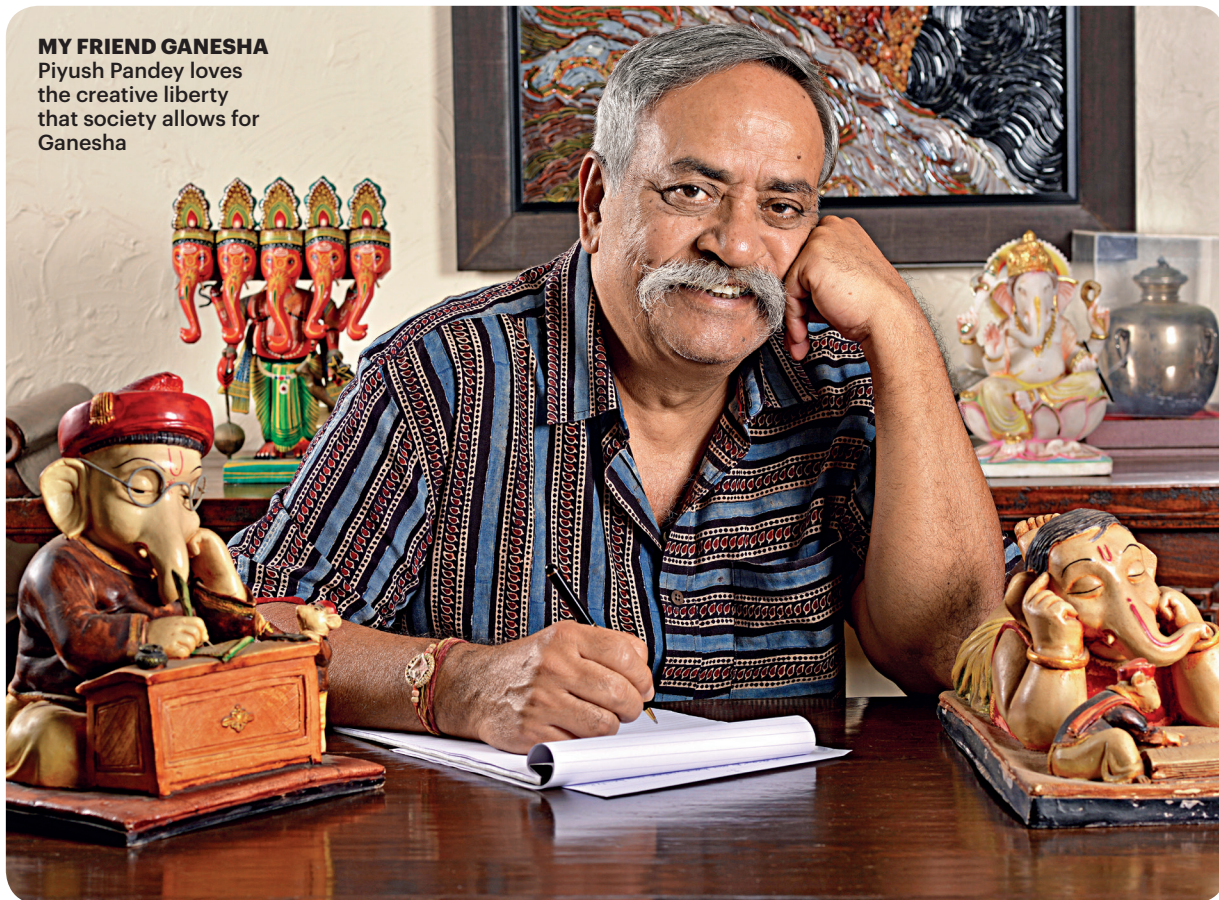


PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

MY FRIEND GANESHA

Piyush Pandey loves the creative liberty that society allows for Ganesha



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THE LORD OF CREATIVITY

Ad man Piyush Pandey's collection of Ganesha idols is made up of gifts from friends and family

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

Ad guru Piyush Pandey has always loved Lord Ganesha, right since childhood when his parents lived next door to Jaipur's famous Ganesh temple. "Unlike Mumbai where Tuesday is Lord Ganesha's day, in Jaipur it is Wednesday. Every Wednesday there used to be a *mela* (fair) outside the temple and we used to all go for *darshan* (to pay respects)," says Pandey, Chairman of Global Creativity and Executive Chairman India of Ogilvy.

Over the years, his love for Ganesha has continued and all those who know him are well aware of this. As a result, he is often gifted Ganesha idols by friends, family and admirers. So much so that he has over 100 pieces today. "I don't think of myself as a collector. People have much bigger collections than mine. But I am very proud of what I have," says the 67-year-old who has given the country some of the most famous tag lines including 'Abki baar Modi sarkar', 'Chal meri Luna', 'Fevicol ka jod' and 'Kuch khaas hai'.

Pandey says that he really loves the creative liberty that society allows for Ganesha. "With this figure, people can play around, do only the trunk, or make only half of him. I have a whole lot of them where he is playing different roles."